Mrs. Bob Cratchit's Wild Christmas Binge

By Christopher Durang

BOY 1: **(Pg 7)** *(singing sweetly)* HARK THE HERALD ANGELS SING, GLORY TO THE NEWBORN KING.

YOUNG EBENEZER: *(irritated, negative)* Bah humbug!

BOY 1: PEACE ON EARTH, AND MERCY MILD; GOD AND SINNER RECONCILED

YOUNG EBENEZER: Phooey! Christmas stinks! Get me a hamburger!

GHOST: *(to audience)* Even as a child, young Ebenezer displayed a pronounced antipathy toward Christmas. *(to Ebenezer)* Merry Christmas, Ebenezer

YOUNG EBENEZER: Bah humbug! I want to put bugs in your hair!

GHOST: *(to audience)* In later centuries, we would probably identify Ebenezer's repeated saying of "Bah humbug" as a kind of seasonal Tourette's Syndrome. However in 1943, when our story is set, we hadn't a clue what it meant – except he was a nasty little child.

YOUNG EBENEZER: Bah humbug! I hate Christmas!

INTRODUCTION

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BOB CRATCHIT: **(Pg 13-15)** Good morning, Mr. Scrooge.

SCROOGE: You still alive, Bob Cratchit? You haven't died of pneumonia yet?

BOB CRATCHIT: Well, I'm very cold, it's true, Mr. Scrooge. Might we put another coal on the fire?

SCROOGE: No, we may not. I am not made of money. A little cold never hurt anyone. Slap yourself in the face, Bob Cratchit.

BOB CRATCHIT: Very well, sir. *(slaps himself in the face)* Mr. Scrooge, there are two gentlemen to see you, sir. *(gentlemen enter)*

GENTLEMAN 2: Merry Christmas to you, sir.

SCROOGE: Bah humbug. Christmas-stinks-Christmas-carols-make-me-puke.

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GENTLEMAN 1: Mr. Scrooge, we are fellow businessmen collecting for the United Way. Every Christmas we give a little bit from our pockets to all the poor people who wander throughout London in poverty and despair. And we wondered how much we could put you down for?

SCROOGE: Nothing. I wish to give nothing. Let the poor go to workhouses, or orphanages, or die in the street. *(he exits)*

GHOST: Clearly Mr. Scrooge needs to be changed. I think a little visit may be in order, don't you? And some scary noises and rattling chains. Coming right up!

*****Scene*****

SCROOGE: **(Pg 17-19)** I am suddenly exhausted *(he nods off to sleep) (Offstage, the sound of ghostly "woo-ing")*

GHOST: *(enters)* UPS delivery. UPS delivery. Mr. Scrooge, I have a package. A Christmas present from all your grateful friends and relatives. (Hold out a box)

SCROOGE: *(takes the box and opens it)* Ah. A pair of socks. *(tosses it aside)* Christmas! Leave me out of it!

GHOST: *(eye rolling and a heavy sigh)* I am the Ghost of Christmas Past. *(Scrooge is not impressed)* The way you receive present is just no good. Try again *(offers him another package)* No before opening, you must proclaim in loud and grateful tones how lovely the wrapping is.

SCROOGE: I don't want to. *(Ghost takes out an electrical zapper and zaps him - ZAP ZAP)* Aaaaggghh! What is that?

GHOST: A zapper. *(threateningly)* If you disobey, I shall use it again and again and again. *(recovers a benevolent attitude)* Now as I said. Make a big fuss over the Christmas wrapping.

SCROOGE: *(with feigned, unconvincing delight)* Oh . . . what a lovely shade of yellow. Makes me think of *(beat)* vomit! *(Ghost zaps him)* Aaaaggghhh! I. . . I . . . hate to even open it, it's so lovely.

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GHOST: Much better. I am the Ghost of Christmas Past, and we have visiting to do. Come touch my arm. *(Scrooge touches the Ghost's arm and there are rustling sounds, like racing through space and time)*

*******Scene*******

GHOST: **(Pg 20-24)** We're at the Cratchit house? We're supposed to be her much later. Something's gone awry.

CHILD 1: I'm hungry.

CHILD 2: Me too. Feed us!

MRS. BOB CRATCHIT: All children want to do is eat, it's disgusting. (Screams at them) When your father finally makes some money, then you'll eat!

CHILD 2: Father and Tiny Tim are home, I think.

MRS. BOB CRATCHIT: I wonder what good news your father will have for Christmas Eve. Maybe Scrooge died and named us in his will. *(laughs bitterly)*

SCROOGE: That's rude.

BOB CRATCHIT: Gladys, we're home. And Tiny Tim enjoyed looking in the store windows at all the Christmas treats he can't have.

TINY TIM: I only fell twenty-four times today!

MRS. BOB CRATCHIT: Use your crutch, you stupid child.

TINY TIM: I don't want people to notice I'm crippled.

MRS. BOB CRATCHIT: And if you fall down twenty-four times, you don't think they'll notice? *(angrily to Bob)* That crutch cost half your weekly salary and the idiot child won't use it!

GHOST: Isn't this a sad family? Do you feel sorry for them?

SCROOGE: *(scoffs)* Why are you showing me this?

MRS. BOB CRATCHIT: *(to Bob)* Did you ask that horrible Mr. Scrooge for a raise as I told you to?

BOB CRATCHIT: Well . . . an amusing story about that . . .

MRS. BOB CRATCHIT: What?! You're missing part of your brain, aren't you. I may go mad right now. I'll go nuts, I'll go crackers.

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CHILD 1: I want a cracker!

MRS. BOB CRATCHIT: *(screams)* Goodbye, children. Mother's going to jump off London bridge. Have a nice Christmas. Goodbye, everyone! (she rushes out)

SCROOGE: *(heartless)* Oh, pooey. If she ends up in Bedlam, that's her problem!

BOB CRATCHIT: *(calling after her)* Gladys, please! It's Christmas Eve! It's a happy time. *(he turns sadly)* Oh, it break my heart. I think we all better cry. On the count of three, everybody weep. *(loud sobbing)*

SCROOGE: Oh, Lord, they're crying! Pathetic!

******Scene*******

MRS. BOB CRATCHIT: **(Pg 29)** *(catching her breath after rushing from her house)* Okay. Okay. *(panting)* I'm ready to die now. Which way to London Bridge?

GHOST: *(rushing after Mrs. Cratchi, and dragging Scrooge along)* Mrs. Cratchit, can you hear me? Listen. You need Paxil or Zoloft. Are you on an antidepressant?

MRS. BOB CRATCHIT: I don't know what you're talking about. Which way to the river?

GHOST: *(pleading)* Just go home to Mr. Cratchit. I'm trying to redeem this man here . . .

SCROOGE: *(interrupting)* Oh, let her kill herself – **(Pg 34)** Christmas is stupid and makes us do stupid, awful things.

GHOST: **(Pg 29)** . . . and you've a part of his story. If you kill yourself, the story has an entirely different meaning.

MRS. BOB CRATCHIT: I'll find the river myself. Merry Christmas, see you in hell! *(Exits)*

GHOST: **(Pg 34)** Oh, God. This isn't going like it's supposed to! **(Pg 37)** I can't have Mr.s Cratchit be dead. I'm going to need all my powers. *(Ghost spreads arms with authority)* Hear me, spirits – I call upon the forces of the wind and sea to bring Mrs. Bob Cratchit back *(nothing happens)*

SCROOGE: **(Pg 24)** I think I should go back to bed, and you should go back to Ghost School or something.

GHOST: . . . RIGHT NOW! *(Mrs. Bob Cratchit appears)*

MRS. BOB CRATCHIT: **(Pg 37)** No! No! No!! I don't want to be here!

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GHOST: (Pg 38) It worked! And from now on, *(waves hands toward Mrs. Cratchitt)* Mrs. Cratchit will behave correctly.

MRS. BOB CRATCHIT: *(Sweetly)* Hello, children. Hello, Bob. Hello, Tiny Tim. Mother's home now. Merry Christmas.

TINY TIM: (Pg 37) Merry Christmas, Mother. **(Pg 41)** Mummy, itsn't it time for Christmas dinner? The goose and the huckleberries and the yams and then the Christmas pudding?

MRS. BOB CRATCHIT: *(the spell dissipates quickly)* I've been trying to drown myself in the Thames – you think I have time to be cooking for you??? God, when will feminism be invented so people won't just assume I'll be cooking all the time AND be positive and pleasant!

TINY TIM: (Pg 47-48) So there's no Christmas dinner and no Christmas pudding. I can't be brave anymore *(begins to cry)*

SCROOGE: So pathetic. It gets on my nerves. Let me treat them to a Christmas dinner. I have money.

GHOST: *(waves arms and bags of food appear on the table)*

TINY TIM: Oooooohhh. Aahhhhh. It's magic! *(quickly opening a bag)* I have a Big Whopper!

MRS. BOB CRATCHIT: Isn't that nice . . . *(she notices the pitiful Christmas tree)* Good God! Who decorated the tree?

TINY TIM: *(with his mouth full)* I did!

MRS. BOB CRATCHIT: Are you blind as well as crippled?

SCROOGE: (Pg 38-39) I like Mrs. Cratchit! She speaks up for herself. It's so unusual.

GHOST: She has a bad attitude.

MRS. BOB CRATCHIT: (Pg 53) I have a realistic attitude. I'm living in 1840s London, there's no plumbing, everybody smells all the time. There's never enough food, my husband earns no money. And I feel so lonely, and hopeless, and the people around me are icky and goody-goody and pitiful, and I wish I had never been born!

SCROOGE: Indeed. That's why she's so delightful. (he winks at Mrs. Cratchit)

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GHOST: (pg 54) I'm so thrown. Nowhere in the story does Scrooge fall in love with Mrs. Bob Cratchit

SCROOGE: I'm not in love . . . (smiling and flirt-waving to Mrs. Cratchit) . . . yet I'm just flirting!

TINY TIM: (Pg 50) Oh dear. I don't feel very well. I have a feeling I may die.

SCROOGE: (Pg 49-50) Oh, God, am I going to have to watch these pathetic children's death scenes?

MRS. BOB CRATCHIT: Nonsense. What would you die of?

TINY TIM: Of being a cripple.

MRS. BOB CRATCHIT: *(scoffs)* That's like saying you're going to die because you have brown hair.

TINY TIM: Nonetheless I feel it. Unless Mr. Scrooge reforms his personality and learns to value Christmas, I can tell I'm going to die. (Bob Cratchit begins crying)

MRS. BOB CRATCHIT: He's not dying! He probably feels ill from the Happy Meal, all that fat and grease. If you need to throw up, use one of the bags the food came in. That's why they put the foot in bags, it's for vomiting in later on. (beat) I've had enough sickness and pathos, and this stupid family where everything is about suffering.

TINY TIM: I think I feel consumption coming on. That's when your little lungs fill up with something and you cough and die, right? (coughs)

MRS. BOB CRATCHIT: Enough! Wallowing in consumption, poverty, no food, no money. This isn't what I signed up for! It's a horrible life.

BOB CRATCHIT: It's a wonderful life. *(a bell tinkles)*

CHILD'S VOICE: *(sweetly)* Teacher says whenever a bell rings, it's an angel getting its wings.

*******Scene*******

GHOST: (Pg 62-63) *(spreads shiny wings)* Well, as you see. I got my wings, whatever that means. *(frowning)* And so, um . . . well the moral of the story confuses me soft of. But there must be one. Let's see. The moral is there are some people who are mean and nasty, but if they enjoy being mean and nasty (like) Scrooge and Mrs. Cratchit, then they're happy.

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(shrugs) I'm sorry if that doesn't sound uplifting, but the story doesn't make sense to me anymore.

TINY TIM: *(sings or hums – From How the Grinch Stole Christmas*)*

Fah who foraze! Dah who doraze!

Welcome Christmas, come this way!

Fah who foraze! Dah who doraze!

Welcome Christmas, Christmas Day!

(Pg 37) . . . God Bless us Everyone!

SCROOGE: (Pg 19) Makes me think of *(beat)* vomit!

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
NIETOC
CO State Qualifier
IL State Qualifier
OH State Qualifier

Whoville Christmas Song (music)
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=QiOBwLLSpI4

Whoville Christmas Song (lyrics)
https://www.songlyricsplace.com/whoville-song-lyrics/

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